Project Payment and Deposit Planner

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Project brief and proposed implementation plan

15 October 2026

We have selected a web application that helps microbusiness owners align deposits and milestone payments with the expenses needed to deliver a project. The chosen stack is React, TypeScript, Supabase and Cloudflare Pages, with the aim of launching within free service tiers.

Purpose and customer problem

A profitable project can still create a cash shortage when materials, subcontractors or other costs must be paid before the client pays. The planner will show these gaps before the owner agrees to a payment schedule and let them compare changes.

Potential users include tradespeople, freelancers and small agencies in Australia. Freelancers and agencies delivering fixed-price projects are the proposed starting audience.

The final customer segment remains an open decision.

Research foundation

The original goal was to identify an untapped opportunity supported by EY research. Two relevant publications were identified: EY Megatrends 2026 and beyond, and the 2022 report The untapped potential for fintech companies to serve small and medium-sized enterprises.

The SME report discusses underserved businesses and challenges involving administration, liquidity and financial services. Its focus is the Nordic market. It supports the broader problem, but does not prove that this product idea is untapped or that the same gap exists in the chosen market today. [1–2]

The defensible project framing is an underserved opportunity supported by EY research. Current competitor analysis and customer interviews are still required.

Selected concept

Owners enter a project price, expected expenses and payment milestones. The tool calculates when cash may run short and shows how changing a deposit or milestone affects the result.

Current status: concept and technology stack selected. Application development has not started.

Ideas considered and selection

Five cash-flow concepts were explored. The payment and deposit planner was selected because it offers a focused user problem, a manageable prototype and a measurable outcome.

Cash flow scenario planner

Shows how purchases, hiring or other decisions affect the next 90 days.

Pros: Answers practical decisions; supports manual-input prototyping; makes shortfalls visible.

Cons: Depends on assumptions; requires updated inputs; overlaps with existing forecasting tools.

Invoice follow up assistant

Tracks overdue invoices and prepares owner-controlled reminders.

Pros: Targets delayed payments; saves administration time; payment speed is measurable.

Cons: Cannot fix inability to pay; messages may affect relationships; accounting tools already offer reminders.

Project payment and deposit planner

Structures deposits and milestone payments around project expenses.

Pros: Addresses shortages before work starts; can focus on one industry; needs limited integration initially.

Cons: Clients may resist staged payments; scope and delays change forecasts; arrangements must suit local rules and contracts.

Income allocation and bill reserves

Suggests reserves for bills, tax, operating costs and owner pay.

Pros: Clarifies available cash; prepares for predictable bills; encourages regular reviews.

Cons: Allocations may not fit uneven costs; cannot fix insufficient income; moving money adds complexity.

Seasonal cash flow planner

Estimates reserves needed to cover quieter trading periods.

Pros: Serves a specific segment; connects seasonal and daily decisions; supports industry-specific assumptions.

Cons: Needs historical data; unexpected events weaken forecasts; infrequent use may hinder subscriptions.

Proposed minimum viable product

The first release should support the journey from creating a project to exporting a payment plan. These features are proposed scope, pending validation with the initial customer group.

Feature	Expected behaviour
Project setup	Capture client, price, dates, currency and available starting cash.
Expense timeline	Record materials, subcontractors and other costs with expected payment dates.
Milestone builder	Set deposit and milestone amounts and timing; verify the total matches the project price.
Cash gap detection	Show when available cash and expected receipts fall below cumulative expenses.
Schedule suggestions	Explain how adjusting payment amounts or timing changes the funding gap.
Scenario testing	Compare late receipts, delayed milestones and increased expenses.
Payment plan export	Produce a clear printable schedule suitable for client discussion.

Illustrative workflow

For a $10,000 project, the owner expects $3,000 of expenses before the first milestone receipt. A $2,000 deposit and no starting cash produce a $1,000 funding gap. The owner compares a larger deposit, an earlier milestone or a later expense, then tests a seven-day payment delay.

Calculation and product rules

- Use expected receipt dates, including payment terms; milestone completion does not mean immediate payment.
- Store money in integer minor units such as cents and keep forecast receipts separate from confirmed payments.
- Make suggestions explainable. Respect configured deposit constraints and show any remaining gap when no feasible schedule exists.
- Preserve schedule versions so a revised plan does not overwrite an earlier agreement.

Possible later features

Industry templates; scope-change planning; actual payment and expense tracking; client review links; and a combined cash-flow view across projects. Bank connections, payment processing, automated reminders and AI explanations can be evaluated after demand is established.

Technology decision and free launch

Option 2 was selected to support real user accounts and saved projects while keeping initial infrastructure spending at $0 within free-tier limits.

Component	Selected technology	Purpose
Interface	React and TypeScript	Project forms, milestones and forecast views
Build tooling	Vite	Local development and production builds
Styling	Tailwind CSS	Consistent responsive interface
Database	Supabase PostgreSQL	Users' business records and schedule versions
Access	Supabase Auth and row-level security	Sign-in and isolation of each business's records
Hosting	Cloudflare Pages	Serve the frontend using a provided subdomain
Exports	Browser print to PDF	Create a printable payment plan
Testing	Vitest	Verify forecasting, rounding and payment scenarios

The initial calculations can run in the browser. A separate application server is not required for the basic planning workflow. Database access policies must enforce ownership independently of the interface.

Alternative stacks considered

Option	Stack	Main trade off
1	React, browser storage, Cloudflare Pages	Simplest prototype; no accounts or cross-device sync
2 selected	React, Supabase, Cloudflare Pages	Accounts and SQL storage; free-tier constraints
3	React, Firebase Auth, Firestore, Firebase Hosting	Integrated services; document model and usage quotas
4	React, Cloudflare Workers and D1, Supabase Auth	Flexible backend; more integration and authorization work

Operating cost assumptions

Start with manual entry, manually recorded receipts, browser calculations and downloadable schedules. Use the hosting subdomain and defer paid integrations. Free infrastructure does not include development labour, a custom domain or future services.

Supabase Free currently lists a 500 MB database and may pause low-activity projects after seven days. Cloudflare static-asset requests are free and unlimited, with separate limits for functions. Recheck service terms and quotas before launch. [3–5]

Vercel was removed from the free commercial-launch recommendation because its Hobby plan is restricted to personal, non-commercial use. [6]

Proposed delivery plan

The following sequence is a proposed next step. Dates, owners and budget have not yet been agreed.

Stage	Work	Completion evidence
1 Validate	Choose segment and country; interview owners; compare current alternatives.	Repeated unmet need and a clear reason to switch
2 Define	Confirm scope, input fields, assumptions and user flows.	Reviewed requirements and sample project scenarios
3 Prototype	Build setup, expenses, milestones and cash forecast.	Working end-to-end planning journey
4 Pilot	Add accounts, access rules, exports and scenario tests; trial with users.	Verified calculations, isolated records and usable exports
5 Review	Assess feedback and free-tier usage; prioritize improvements.	Decision to refine, expand or change direction

Key risks and validation questions

- Demand: Do owners need a separate planner, and what is missing from their current tools?
- Adoption: Can users complete a useful plan without excessive data entry?
- Forecast accuracy: Are payment dates and costs realistic, and do users understand the assumptions?
- Client acceptance: Will clients accept the suggested schedule?
- Market fit: Which industry and country offer a specific, defensible starting opportunity?

Suggested success measures

Track time to produce a plan, users' ability to identify a funding gap, completion of the planning workflow and whether owners change payment terms before quoting. These are proposed measures; numerical targets should follow initial user research.

Sources

Research and platform references discussed during planning. Pricing and plan conditions may change.

[1] EY Megatrends 2026 and beyond

[2] EY findings on the untapped potential of SME fintech

[3] Supabase pricing

[4] Supabase free project pausing

[5] Cloudflare Pages pricing

[6] Vercel Hobby plan